Compare the SOC analyst, VAPT/penetration tester and incident responder roles in a table: goal, daily work, tools, blue/red team.

SOC Analyst vs VAPT/Penetration Tester vs Incident Responder

Cybersecurity professionals perform different responsibilities depending on whether they are defending systems, testing security, or responding to attacks.

Basis	SOC Analyst	VAPT / Penetration Tester	Incident Responder
Primary goal	Detect and monitor threats	Identify and validate vulnerabilities	Contain attacks and restore systems
Daily work	Monitor alerts, investigate logs, triage incidents	Scan systems, test security controls, document findings	Investigate breaches, isolate systems, analyze evidence
Tools	Splunk, Wazuh, Microsoft Sentinel, Wireshark	Nmap, Burp Suite, Nessus, Metasploit	Velociraptor, Volatility, Wireshark, EDR tools
Team	Blue Team	Red Team / offensive security	Blue Team
Approach	Defensive and continuous	Proactive and assessment-based	Reactive and investigative
Main output	Alerts, tickets, incident escalations	Vulnerability assessment and penetration test reports	Incident reports, containment actions, recovery plans

A. SOC Analyst

A Security Operations Centre (SOC) Analyst continuously monitors organizational networks, endpoints, and applications to identify suspicious activities.

Example:

A SOC analyst detects multiple failed login attempts from an unfamiliar IP address using Splunk and investigates whether it is a brute-force attack.

B. VAPT / Penetration Tester

VAPT stands for Vulnerability Assessment and Penetration Testing.

- Vulnerability Assessment (VA): Identifies and prioritizes weaknesses in systems.
- Penetration Testing (PT): Safely attempts to exploit authorized weaknesses to determine their actual security impact.

Example:

A penetration tester identifies an SQL injection vulnerability in an authorized test application and demonstrates its impact within the agreed scope.

C. Incident Responder

An Incident Responder investigates and manages security incidents to reduce damage and restore normal operations.

Example: During a ransomware incident, the responder isolates affected computers, preserves forensic evidence, investigates the infection, and coordinates recovery.

Important distinction: A SOC analyst usually detects and escalates suspicious activity, a penetration tester identifies weaknesses before attackers exploit them, and an incident responder manages confirmed or suspected security incidents.